

ADDENDUM: OTHER COLLABORATORS

by [Justin Alexander](#) – April 16th, 2019



One of the first elements I established for the Alexandrian Remix of [Dragon Heist](#) was to have the Cassalanter approach the PCs and attempt to recruit them as their agents in the Grand Game: I found the story of their children's plight very compelling, and the entire situation rife with incredibly tough and emotional decisions that I felt would really elevate the campaign if they were put center stage. (Whereas in a traditional run, even with the Cassalanter as the DM's chosen villain, it's very likely that the PCs will never even discover what the Cassalanter's true motives are.)

But what if we went a different way?

There are four rival factions in *Dragon Heist*, of which the Cassalanter are only one. If it's interesting to swap the Cassalanter's approach from open antagonism to would-be collaborators, what might happen if one of the *other* factions took the same approach?

Of course, none of the other rivals have innocent children for the PCs to be called upon to save. So their approach to collaboration will look a little different.

MANSHOON'S ULTIMATUM

The timing of Manshoon's approach can be identical to the Cassalanter (he discovers the PCs are investigating the *fireball* that killed several of his agents and decides they would be useful pawns), but it might be better to wait until the fallout from the Gralhund Villa raids. Assuming that the PCs end up with the *Stone of Golorr*, Manshoon would be highly motivated to get them onboard.

His method for doing so, however, is far less discrete than the Cassalanter: He takes a hostage.

Circumstance will determine whether it will work best to find someone in a PC's backstory or to target someone they've built a relationship with during the campaign, but either way the kidnapping takes place offscreen. Perhaps the PC becomes aware of it when they find their loved ones' ransacked quarters, but more likely it takes the form of a simple letter arriving at Trollskull Manor.

The letter explains the situation simply: They have something he wants. And now he has something they want. A meeting will be arranged (to which Manshoon will send his simulacrum rather than appearing himself), and the following proposal will be made:

- Their loved one will not be harmed. Quite the contrary. They are enjoying luxurious accommodations (If only the PCs could be so lucky.) Manshoon is personally seeing to it that their every need (except freedom) is being met.
- The PCs will seek to restore the *Stone of Golorr* and use it to claim Neverember's Enigma – the 500,000 golden dragons he embezzled from the city.
- Manshoon is not an unreasonable man, of course, and if the PCs fulfill their end of the bargain, not only will he free their loved one, they will also be free to keep fully 20% of the treasure.
- The Zhentarim will also make available to the PCs the full resources of their intelligence-gathering and mercenary networks.



IF THE PCs JOIN MANSHOON: The Zhentarim response teams and safe houses are put at their disposal, with more and more resources being made available as they prove themselves more trustworthy. All of Manshoon's lieutenants can be played as allies, and this extra muscle will certainly free the PCs up to try more daring (or, at least, direct) heists to obtain the missing eyes.

IF THE PCs REFUSE: Manshoon shakes his head sadly. Then he leaves, has their loved one murdered, and dumps the corpse on the front step of Trollskull Manor.

IF THE PCs SEEK TO RESCUE THE HOSTAGE: A heist! I love heists. The hostage is being held in Area E11 of Manshoon's Extradimensional Sanctum. The Zhents who made their quarters there have been turned out for the moment; consider spreading them out between Kolat Towers and the Zhentarim faction outposts.

JARLAXLE'S ALLIANCE



For Jarlaxle, we'll move in the opposite direction: When [running the opening scene of the campaign at the Yawning Portal](#), instead of using Step 2: Friendly Faces (in which the PCs pick one of the NPCs on p. 221 of *Dragon Heist* to be the contact they've come to meet), the contact they're meeting with is, in fact, Jarlaxle.

Depending on the approach you want to take, they might think they're meeting with "Captain Zord" or they might know the true identity of who they're meeting. Either way, Jarlaxle does, in fact, connect them with Volo.

This means, of course, that the PCs are members of Bregan D'Aerthe from the very beginning. Refer to the general information on p. 14-15 of *Dragon Heist* and the faction missions on p. 34-35.

INVERTED NIMBLEWRIGHT INVESTIGATION: If you want to radically shift Chapter 2 of the campaign, then have one of the PCs' jobs be to *sell the nimblewrights* for Jarlaxle. One of the reasons Jarlaxle wanted to get on Volo's good side was so that Volo could help make introductions to various guilds, nobles, and other highly-placed and influential people. Refer to the list of owners in [Part 5C: The Nimblewright Investigation](#) as a resource for the prospective clients Volo refers them to.

Whether the PCs are selling nimblewrights or not, they still have Trollskull Manor as a reward from Volo. Jarlaxle will help bankroll the renovation costs and is eager to develop it as a safehouse for Bregan D'Aerthe operatives.

The *fireball* explosion also still happens on schedule: When the PCs discover that a nimblewright is involved, they can either go to Jarlaxle and clue their whole organization into the Grand Game. Or it's possible that they were literally the ones who sold the nimblewright to the Gralhunds. (Small world, eh?)

THE GRAND GAME: Tracking forward, slot in the PCs everywhere that the campaign refers to Jarlaxle's agents.

At Gralhund Villa they're able to review nimblewright footage in Jarlaxle's *crystal ball* and are then ordered to set up a surveillance post. (Maybe they even end up in Artheyn Manor, just like Fel'Rekt would in a 'normal' campaign.)

I recommend *not* having Jarlaxle accompany them on the other heists (he has a lot of other projects and [a busy social calendar](#) to attend to), but they can certainly tap Bregan D'Aerthe resources (in the form of a response team). And Jarlaxle may be able to directly feed them information (and access) to Xanathar's Lair.

XANATHAR'S GANGSTERS



For this final collaboration we're going to *radically* invert the campaign: Rather than starting the campaign at the Yawning Portal, the PCs will be gangsters working for Xanathar. Their first job? Raiding a warehouse where the Zhentarim are holding Renaer Neverember, capture Renaer themselves, and bring him to a sewer hideout where they'll be met by Nihiloor.

Of course, they discover too late that they've kidnapped some fuckin' mook named Floon Blagmaar. A total disaster. Maybe they try to double back to the warehouse, but by the time they get there, Renaer is gone and the place is swarming with watchmen. (Their first inklings that a Grand Game is happening will come from the questions Nihiloor asks 'Renaer'.)

CHAPTER 2 – WORKING FOR THE BOSS: You need some time to pass here and, in this scenario, the PCs don't get Trollskull Manor. Run a few faction missions that introduce them to the [Xanatharian faction outposts](#) (they get outfitted by Grinda Garloth; they struggle to figure out how to get the mechanical flying beholder working before the Twin Parades; they're charged with running security at Terasse Estate and escorting gamblers through the dangerous tunnels to the gladiator tournaments).

Their contact person for these faction missions? Dalakhar.

CHAPTER 3 – THE TRAITOR: Then comes the day when Dalakhar vanishes. Turns out he’s betrayed the Boss and stolen something. Boss won’t say what, but it’s clearly important. The PCs need to find him.

They track him to the [Inn of the Dripping Dagger](#). The timeline is slightly different in this version of reality, and they end up finding the letter from Kalain. They track Dalakhar to Kalain’s place, and she tells them he’s headed to some place called Trollskull Manor. (You’ll want to buff this up a bit to fully satisfy the Three Clue Rule.)

The PCs head over to Trollskull Manor. As they’re heading through the alley, a huge explosion goes off just around the corner up ahead: Rushing forward, they discover Dalakhar and a bunch of other people dead!

THE TROLLSKULL MANOR TEAM: From this point forward, the campaign more-or-less follows the normal track. Investigations will lead the PCs to Gralhund Villa; they’ll find the Zhentarim and Jarlaxle’s team watching the place.

But here’s the twist: There *is* a group of heroes who rescued Renaer Neverember and moved into the Trollskull Manor. And they’re doing what the PCs in a ‘normal’ *Dragon Heist* campaign would have been doing: The PCs likely first spot the Trollskull Manor Team at Gralhund Villa, but they’ll keep turning up:

- They raid one of Xanathar’s sewer hideouts.
- They perform a heist at Xanathar’s Lair. (Maybe the PCs can foil it. Or maybe the PCs foil their attempt, only to have Jarlaxle simultaneously steal the Eye. Guess it’s time to pursue them back to the *Eyecatcher* for a heist-in-kind.)
- While the PCs are trying to perform a heist at Kolat Tower, the Trollskull Manor Team is simultaneously active onsite.

And so forth. Play the heroes actively, and figure out what faction(s) they belong to and bring those into play, too.

CONCLUDING THOUGHTS

The cool thing here is that, once you’ve restructured the campaign components into [scenarios instead of plots](#), you can use those components in myriad ways. These examples push that to an extreme, but it demonstrates how much flexibility this approach has and how easy it is to take material prepped in this way and actively play it in order to respond to player choice.

Compare this to the approach taken by the published campaign, which attempts to give you flexibility and ‘reusability’ by, for example, giving you three different versions of an Old Tower. But the truth is that you don’t need multiple versions of a tower in order to get different utility out of it during actual play.

The other thing I’ll point out is that in all of these collaborator scenarios – including the original remixed version with the Cassalanter – we have *no idea* what’s going to happen. Do they take the Cassalanter’s offers or refuse it? Do the Xanatharian gangsters take the money and use it to take over the organization, launching a bloody gang war in and below the streets of Waterdeep? When Jarlaxle’s agents tweak to his true identity, do they remain loyal or turn on him?

Just as the flexibility of the material allows us to reframe the presentation of the campaign, it also provides infinite variability in the actual running of the campaign, providing you (and your players) with a constant stream of surprise and wonder.